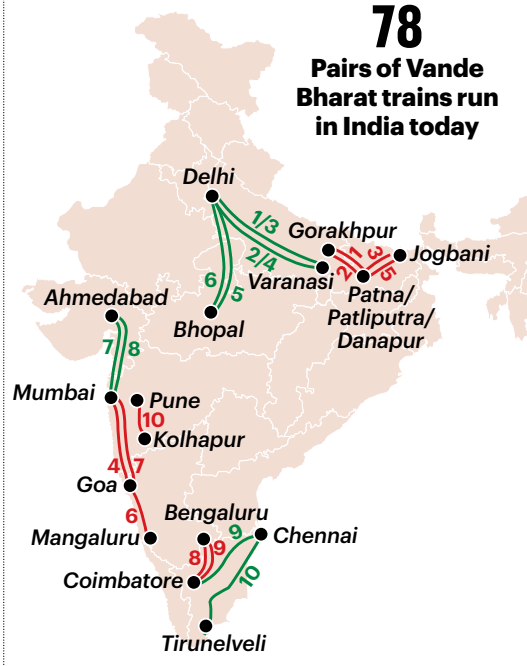
SLOW COACHES

Even the fastest Vande Bharat routes manage barely half of the permitted 160 kmph

10 SLOWEST ROUTES

Average speed

1. Gorakhpur - Patliputra **54.23 kmph**
2. Patliputra - Gorakhpur **54.87 kmph**
3. Danapur - Jogbani, Bihar **55.7 kmph**
4. CST, Mumbai - Madgaon, Goa **55.76 kmph**
5. Jogbani - Danapur, Bihar **55.8 kmph**
6. Mangaluru Central- Madgaon, Goa **56.57 kmph**
7. Madgaon, Goa - CST, Mumbai **58.04 kmph**
8. Coimbatore - Bengaluru Cantonment **58.11 kmph**
9. Bengaluru Cant. - Coimbatore **59.04 kmph**
10. Pune - Kolhapur **60.19 kmph**



10 FASTEST ROUTES

Average speed

1. New Delhi - Varanasi* **94.92 kmph**
2. Varanasi - New Delhi* **94.91 kmph**
3. New Delhi - Varanasi* **93.94 kmph**
4. Varanasi - New Delhi* **93.89 kmph**
5. Bhopal - Nizamuddin, Delhi **92.01 kmph**
6. Nizamuddin, Delhi - Bhopal **92.01 kmph**
7. Ahmedabad - Mumbai Central **90.45 kmph**
8. Mumbai Central - Ahmedabad **89.08 kmph**
9. Coimbatore - Chennai **85.46 kmph**
10. Chennai Egmore - Tirunelveli **84.22 kmph**

These routes have two pairs of trains

WHY THE DRAG

Over 90 per cent of India's network caps at 110 kmph. Why speed upgrades hit the brakes and how to fix them

LOOP CHOKE POINTS

Trains slow to 30 kmph on loop lines, even where mainline speeds are 130. Upgrades to 50 exist, but remain unused

The fix: Raise loop-line speeds to 50 kmph using Thick Web Switches, already standard on freight corridors

RESTRICTIONS EVERYWHERE

As of March 2025, Railways had over 8,000 temporary and 9,000 permanent speed restrictions, many as low as 15-45 kmph

The fix: Prioritise removal of all restrictions below 75 kmph

NEW LINES, OLD PROBLEMS

More than 140 newly built sections run below planned speed, some stuck at 70-80 kmph years after commissioning

The fix: Enforce quality on new projects so they open at planned speeds, not decades later

WEAKEST LINK EFFECT

A line's performance is dictated by its slowest section; so averages collapse despite high-tech trains

The fix: Don't just count kilometres laid, judge by sustained operational speed

than 140 newly constructed sections continued to permit speeds much lower than planned even years after commissioning. In most railway divisions, the level of speed restriction is determined by the Permanent Way Inspector, who is responsible for track maintenance.

Much of India's railway network also remains unfenced, cutting through fields, villages and crowded settlements. Cattle and people wander in freely. "Speeding up trains above 150 kmph is fraught with safety issues," says Mohammad Jamshed, former member (traffic), Railway Board, and now with the Chintan Research Foundation. "You need fenced tracks, automatic signalling, anti-collision devices, grade separators and automated maintenance."

High Spend, Low Speed

Upgrades are doable, and better done early. To its credit, Indian Railways has invested heavily under the Narendra Modi government. High-speed sections of 130 kmph and above have grown from 5,036 km in 2014 to 23,010 km in 2025, raising their share of the total track length from 6.3 per cent to 21.8 per cent. Over 3,500 km of fencing has been erected, 12,000 level crossings removed and the Kavach safety system installed on 1,465 km.

Yet the benefits are patchy. "Indian rolling stock has been good for 130 kmph for 20 years. Tracks never allowed it. For Vande Bharat, nothing has changed," says Subhranshu, who led the team at the Chennai-based